



A FREE GUIDE FROM JOEL POLLEY, RN

The Blood Pressure Blueprint

The 5 hidden triggers behind rising numbers, and what to address first for each one.

1. The Stress Spike
2. The Sugar Surge
3. The Sodium Trap
4. The Midnight Drift
5. The Stillness Trigger

By Joel Polley, RN. Twenty years in ICU and Emergency Medicine.

BEFORE YOU START

You didn't do this to yourself.

I spent twenty years in ICU and emergency medicine, and I can tell you the same story over and over: a patient doing everything they were told. Medication. "Eating better." Trying to move more. And still watching their numbers climb. Every time, they'd ask me the same question, half apologizing: "What am I doing wrong?"

Almost always, the honest answer was: nothing. They just hadn't been shown where to actually look.

Blood pressure isn't one problem. It's a handful of everyday patterns, stacking on top of each other, mostly invisible, that add up to a number that feels random but isn't. This guide walks through the five I see most often. You'll probably recognize yourself in more than one.

Read the one that feels loudest first. Then come back for the rest. They're almost always layered together.

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The Stress Spike

This isn't about being less stressed. It's about how long your body stays in the "on" position.

When your body perceives pressure (a deadline, an argument, just never getting a quiet moment) it releases cortisol and adrenaline. Those hormones are built to spike and settle. But when the stress never fully lets up, your vessels stay primed and tightened longer than they're built to, and your reading climbs right along with it.

This is why a cuff reading at the doctor's office can run higher than one you'd take at home. It's not "white coat syndrome" as a character flaw. It's your nervous system doing exactly what it's designed to do, just too often.

WHAT THIS MIGHT LOOK LIKE

- You feel calm on the surface but your resting heart rate creeps up during ordinary tasks
- A reading at the doctor's office runs noticeably higher than one at home
- Your jaw, shoulders, or hands are tense and you're not sure when it started

3 THINGS TO START TODAY

HERB	Ashwagandha. A traditional adaptogen many people use to support the body's stress response.
FOOD SWAP	Cut the caffeine (swap to chamomile or hibiscus tea), and add magnesium-rich foods like pumpkin seeds and leafy greens.
LIFESTYLE SHIFT	Build one deliberate down-shift into your day. Even 3 slow breaths before opening your inbox.

The Sugar Surge

It's not the dessert. It's the crash that follows it.

Every time blood sugar spikes and then crashes, your body releases stress hormones to bring it back into balance. The same hormones involved in raising blood pressure. Do that several times a day, most days, and your system never gets a real break between corrections.

This isn't about willpower or "being good." It's about how often your blood sugar is swinging without you ever feeling the word "sugar" enter your mind. A fast lunch. A snack to push through the afternoon. A starchy dinner eaten quickly.

WHAT THIS MIGHT LOOK LIKE

- Energy dips hard mid-afternoon, and a snack is the only fix that works
- You feel "hangry" if a meal is delayed even 30 to 45 minutes
- Cravings hit hardest a couple hours after eating, not right away

3 THINGS TO START TODAY

HERB	Cinnamon. Commonly used to support a healthy blood sugar response when added to meals.
FOOD SWAP	Pair carbs with protein or fiber instead of eating them alone. It softens the swing.
LIFESTYLE SHIFT	A short walk after eating, even 10 minutes, measurably softens a blood sugar spike.

The Sodium Trap

It's rarely the salt shaker. It's what's already in the food before you touch it.

Most excess sodium isn't coming from the shaker on your table. It's baked into bread, sauces, canned goods, deli meat, and "healthy" frozen meals, usually paired with too little potassium from fresh produce to help balance it out.

That imbalance makes your body hold onto extra fluid. More fluid means your heart is pushing more volume through the same space, and the pressure has to go somewhere.

WHAT THIS MIGHT LOOK LIKE

- Rings, socks, or waistbands feel tighter by evening than they did that morning
- Swelling in ankles or hands after restaurant meals or packaged dinners
- Thirst hits harder than usual after certain meals

3 THINGS TO START TODAY

HERB	Hibiscus. Traditionally used to support healthy fluid balance and circulation.
FOOD SWAP	Add one potassium-rich food most days: banana, sweet potato, spinach, or beans.
LIFESTYLE SHIFT	For one week, just read sodium on labels the way you'd read sugar. Notice before you change.

The Midnight Drift

Your blood pressure is supposed to dip at night. Fragmented sleep means it never gets the chance to.

Healthy blood pressure normally dips during deep sleep. It's your cardiovascular system's one real recovery window in a 24-hour day. Waking at 2 or 3 a.m., or sleep that never quite reaches that deep stage, means the dip never fully happens.

Your system runs the whole night closer to daytime levels, and the numbers never get their scheduled break, no matter how many hours you technically spent in bed.

WHAT THIS MIGHT LOOK LIKE

- You wake up around the same time most nights, even without an alarm
- Mornings feel like you never actually powered down
- Your energy is worse than the hours you slept would suggest

3 THINGS TO START TODAY

HERB	Chamomile or passionflower. Traditional herbs many people use to wind down before bed.
FOOD SWAP	Avoid heavy or sugary meals within 2 to 3 hours of bedtime. They work against the nightly dip.
LIFESTYLE SHIFT	Anchor one consistent wake time, even on weekends. It does more than a strict bedtime.

The Stillness Trigger

This isn't about workouts. It's about how long your vessels go without a signal to move.

Movement is what keeps blood vessels flexible and responsive. It's about far more than burning calories. Long stretches of sitting, whether at a desk, in a car, or on the couch, mean your vessels aren't getting the regular signal to stay pliable.

Over time, they respond more sluggishly to normal daily demands, and your baseline reading can creep up even on days that felt completely calm.

WHAT THIS MIGHT LOOK LIKE

- You feel stiff getting up after long stretches at a desk, in the car, or on the couch
- A full day passes with barely any real movement, even a "busy" one
- You feel noticeably better on days you happen to walk more

3 THINGS TO START TODAY

HERB	Hawthorn. A traditional herb associated with healthy circulation and vascular support.
FOOD SWAP	Add plant omega-3s a few times a week: walnuts, flaxseed, or chia seeds.
LIFESTYLE SHIFT	Set a movement break every 60 to 90 minutes. Even 2 minutes of standing and stretching counts.

PUTTING IT TOGETHER

Most people are carrying two or three of these at once.

That's normal, and it's actually good news. It means you don't need to overhaul everything at once. Pick the trigger that felt loudest as you read, start with the 3 things on that page, and give it a few weeks before adding another.

1	The Stress Spike	Your nervous system stays “on” longer than it should.
2	The Sugar Surge	Blood sugar swings keep triggering stress hormones.
3	The Sodium Trap	Hidden sodium without enough potassium to balance it.
4	The Midnight Drift	Sleep that never lets your numbers dip at night.
5	The Stillness Trigger	Vessels losing flexibility from too little movement.

Ready to address these at the root?

The BraveWorks BP Reset Kit was built by Joel for exactly this: practical, nurse-designed support for the trigger that's loudest for you. Take the quiz at bpquiz.com if you haven't already, or go straight to the kit.

This guide is for general education and lifestyle awareness only. It is not medical advice, and it is not a substitute for diagnosis, treatment, or guidance from your physician. Always talk with your doctor before making changes related to blood pressure, medication, or any diagnosed condition. If you experience symptoms such as chest pain, severe headache, vision changes, or shortness of breath, seek emergency medical care immediately.